



MANMOHAN AND FOREIGN MINISTER S.M. KRISHNA AT SHARM EL-SHEIKH

Kasab, one of the Mumbai attackers, was caught alive. Besides, 26/11 was the first terror attack in India in which several foreign nationals, including those from the US and 15 other nations, had died. So this was the real game changer which forced Pakistan to act. But this cannot be an excuse for yielding to Pakistan. What Manmohan also failed to address was that Pakistan has done little to nab big fish like LET supremo Hafiz Mohammed Saeed, who has been chargesheeted by India in the 26/11 attacks. Also, Home Minister P. Chidambaram has gone on record stating that Pakistan is not doing enough to bring the 26/11 perpetrators to justice. Besides, the terrorism infrastructure still remains intact in Pakistan.

Even though the Congress, which had distanced itself from the joint

statement, managed a united front in the Parliament with regular intervals of desk thumping as he spoke, the prime minister was not as convincing.

While he made a clearer enunciation of the reasons for what transpired at Sharm el-Sheikh, Manmohan couldn't explain why this had not been reflected in the joint statement.

Earlier, the Congress had watched in alarm as the Opposition made much of the suggestion to delink terrorism from the composite dialogue. Did this

tion where it refuses to talk to Pakistan. Whenever the prime minister tries some out-of-box thinking, whether it is on the nuclear deal or economic reforms, he first gets flak and then support."

Even though, for now, Manmohan may have silenced the political criticism over the joint statement, Sharm el-Sheikh has opened a window of opportunity for a fragmented Opposition that was in disarray.

In Parliament, while the NDA took

Question of Answers

Opposition's Charges

- Why did you de-link the composite dialogue process from terrorism?
- Can you trust Pakistan after Sharm el-Sheikh?
- Why did you make a U-turn on dialogue with Pakistan?
- Why was Balochistan included in the joint statement?

Manmohan's Reply

- The composite dialogue process will not resume till Pakistan takes credible action on terror.
- We have to trust them but have to verify facts on the ground.
- For the first time, they shared progress on terror investigations.
- We have nothing to hide; our record is like an open book.

mean that the prime minister will continue talks with Pakistan even as it continues sponsoring terror in India? A visibly uncomfortable Congress spokesperson Abhishek Singhvi mumbled: "Ask the Government, not the party." With the Maharashtra elections due in October, no Congress leader wanted to support Manmohan on this one. Neither did any leader come out in support of the inclusion of Balochistan in the statement.

The compromise was worked out at a meeting of the Congress core group at the prime minister's residence on July 24. It was decided that the 'clarification' would be given by the prime minister himself. He would reiterate the pre-Sharm el-Sheikh stand on the composite dialogue if Pakistan continued with terror activities against India. A PMO official defended the joint statement: "The prime minister firmly believes that in order to emerge as a global superpower, India cannot take a posi-

the lead, even submitting a memorandum to the President protesting the Indo-Pak joint statement, former allies like Samajwadi Party leader Mulayam Singh Yadav questioned his decision to talk to Pakistan and asked him to throw the joint statement into a dustbin. While the Congress could do little else than support the prime minister, albeit belatedly, some differences were visible even on the floor of the House as instead of the senior leaders and veteran ministers, it was left to a line-up led by the Congress MP from Kerala P.C. Chako to defend the prime minister. The brief was simple: attack the BJP with Kargil, Kandahar and the Parliament attack instead of defending the statement. The defence was left to Manmohan.

While the prime minister has tried to present a brave face, the B-word will continue to trouble India and there is a slim chance that his gamble on Pakistan will succeed this time.

With inputs from Priya Sahgal